

GOING BIG ON DARK STORES

DARK STORES ARE TAKING INDIAN CITIES BY STORM AS BLINKIT, SWIGGY INSTAMART, ZEPTO, BIGBASKET, AMAZON NOW, FLIPKART MINUTES AND JIOMART RACE TO DELIVER QUICK COMMERCE ORDERS

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BY **KARAN DHAR**

ON A FOGGY winter morning in Vaishali, a part of the Delhi NCR (National Capital Region) in Uttar Pradesh's Ghaziabad, two-wheeler riders wait outside a dark store of the Tata Group-owned BigBasket.

The customer promise—a 10-minute delivery.

The store, inconspicuously housed in the lower deck of a small mall, came up last year and houses staff who work ceaselessly—three shifts—to ensure this 24/7 operation never slips up. Quietly, and without fuss, they pick and pack items in brown paper bags before handing them to bikers who quickly rush to the store as soon as you place the order.

Welcome to the world of dark stores, the backbone that brings you that pouch of curd or the kilo of dal and rice, or anything else that you need not just quickly but right now. The term, called quick commerce, once esoteric, now rolls off our tongue easily; and its success owes in no small measure to the multitude of dark stores. In fact, quick commerce apps must be among the most used on your phone, second only, perhaps, to WhatsApp.

WHY IT MATTERS

For companies, quick commerce is an indispensable tool that gives a sense of where the consumer's money is being spent. BigBasket, which used to rely on cus-